people at large. Lawyers' strikes had been sparked off by inane things like a judge objecting to not being addressed as 'Your Honour'; cases being dismissed because the pleader came in late; and political demands for the formation of a separate Telangana state (by bifurcating Andhra Pradesh).

Meanwhile, the office of the administrator of Delhi conceded to the demands of the lawyers and issued orders countermanding the enquiry by Justice Khanna. It felt that a fresh commission should be constituted to look into the entire matter from its genesis onwards. As a result, a two-bench commission, comprising Justice N. N. Goswami and Justice D. P. Wadhwa, was set up.

The Goswami–Wadhwa Commission was asked to give an interim report within a specified time. It did. It held Kiran Bedi guilty on all possible counts. Soon after that Kiran was transferred to the Central Reserve Police Force, an order to be reversed within 24 hours by the personal intervention of none other than Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi. He had called her for a personal meeting in which he suggested that her talents would be better utilized in the interdiction of drug trafficking (see also Chapter 9).

But little did the prime minister or Kiran realize what a marathon legal battle lay ahead. Kiran used to start the day in the lawyer's chamber, if she was lucky to have a lawyer, then go to the courts for her hearings that had assumed the shape of a public trial, then rush to attend office in the Narcotics Control Bureau and then return to the lawyer's chamber to prepare for the next day's hearings or prepare herself with her colleagues, namely, M. S. Sandhu, S. B. S. Tyagi, Vinay Chaudhury, Prabhat Singh, Jinder Singh and others, all serving officers of the Delhi Police. There were days in which Kiran had to be physically present in three courts, that is, before the commission of inquiry, the Delhi High Court and the Supreme Court. She was appearing in person, defending herself, while the seniormost of the counsel, K. K. Venugopal, would be pitted against her.

Kiran lived by the hour then, as she says: morning, afternoon, evening and night. Her day, she adds, was divided into four major portions when scenes changed and so did the priorities and strategies. The slogan of a section of the lawyers was a 'fight to the finish! We must get Kiran Bedi's scalp'. This was a battle where one woman was visibly pitted against a large organized union of lawyers. Both sides had their grievances, without a doubt but, who was the accused and who the accuser? Kiran for the first time became a lawyer who appeared for herself and filed a petition before the apex court. She recalls the help given to her by a friend, Anil Bal. He introduced her to a senior advocate, Gopal Subramaniam, who gave all possible legal guidance and staff assistance, which enabled her to prepare her petitions and appear before the Supreme Court in person. The rulings given by the Supreme Court in her case are already part of legal history and are quoted as landmark judgements delivered by Mr Justice E. S. Venkataramiah, Mr Justice M. M. Dutt and Mr Justice N. D. Ojha. Kiran had gone to the highest court, questioning her status of accused before the commission of inquiry and therefore seeking the right to defend herself. When the commission of inquiry had asked her to take the witness box to be examined, she took the stand and said, 'I do not wish to make a statement, your lordship. I beg leave to state that.' The judges did not say anything for some time and only then did Justice Wadhwa suggest that she take a chair while he consulted his colleague. 'I am used to standing for long periods,' answered Kiran.

'Are you advising your client not to take oath?' Justice Wadhwa asked G. Ramaswamy (Kiran's counsel). 'She can be prosecuted for contempt of court,' he was told.

'I am only asking that my client be given an opportunity to defend herself, your honour,' said her counsel. 'You cannot force her to take that opportunity without examining the witnesses first.'

Ramaswamy then asked the judges to overrule his plea if they so thought fit so that 'we can move the higher courts'.